

EGS3012S: EGS AI policy

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An important component of academic integrity relates to the use of AI:

1 GenAI policy



1.1 EGS AI statement and policy

1.1.1 Statement on the Responsible Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI)

Artificial intelligence (AI), including generative AI tools such as large language models, is now a routine part of academic, professional, and public life. The Department of Environmental & Geographical Science (EGS) recognises that AI tools can support aspects of learning, teaching, and research, while also posing significant risks to academic integrity, skill development, and ethical research practice.

This statement sets out the Department's position on the appropriate and responsible use of AI by students and staff in teaching, learning, and research. It should be read in conjunction with University of Cape Town policies, Faculty of Science guidance, and relevant ethics and integrity frameworks, including:

- [The University of Cape Town Senate Ethics in Research Committee \(EiRC\) Guidelines and Recommendations for the Use of Generative AI Tools in Research](#)
- Guidance from the Centre for Innovation in Learning and Teaching ([CILT](#)) on assessment and academic integrity in the context of AI use.

1.1.2 Core principles

The EGS Department approaches AI use through the following principles:

- Human responsibility and accountability: AI tools do not replace scholarly judgement. Students and staff remain fully responsible for the accuracy, originality, and integrity of all submitted work.
- Transparency: Any permitted use of AI must be openly declared in line with course, departmental, and university requirements.
- Skill development: Core disciplinary skills, including critical reading, data analysis, writing, argumentation, field observation, and ethical reasoning, must be developed independently of AI.
- Research integrity and ethics: AI use must align with UCT research ethics codes, authorship policies, and legal obligations, including data protection and consent requirements.
- Equity and epistemic awareness: Users should be alert to bias, exclusion, and Global North dominance embedded in many AI systems, particularly in environmental and geographical research contexts.

1.1.3 AI use in teaching and learning

The Department shares the University's concern that inappropriate AI use can undermine student learning and lead to academic dishonesty. In line with Faculty of Science policy, the majority of summative assessment is conducted under controlled, in-person conditions.

The EGS Department's default position is that assessed work must reflect the student's own reading, analysis, interpretation, and writing, and must not be substantially generated by generative AI tools. This includes the generation of arguments, interpretations, or written text for submission.

Limited use of AI tools for specific purposes (for example, brainstorming broad topics, checking clarity or grammar, or exploring presentation formats) may be permitted where explicitly stated by the lecturer. Where such use is permitted, the scope and purpose of AI use will be clearly defined in the course or assignment instructions, and all use must be transparently declared.

The primary task of students in EGS remains the development of core academic skills independent of AI, including critical reading, data analysis, synthesis, and disciplinary writing.

1.1.4 Permitted low risk uses

Where explicitly authorised by the lecturer, AI tools may be used in limited, low-risk ways that support learning without substituting for core academic work. These may include:

- Brainstorming broad topics or research questions
- Improving clarity, grammar, or presentation of text written by the student
- Generating ideas for data visualisation or presentation formats
- Checking logic, calculations, or code, provided all outputs are independently verified

In all cases, students must ensure that they understand every step of the work and are able to explain and defend it without reliance on AI tools.

1.1.5 Prohibited or high-risk uses

Unless explicitly authorised in writing by the lecturer for a specific task, the following uses are not permitted in EGS courses:

- Generating full or partial assignments, essays, reports, or reflective pieces
- Producing arguments, interpretations, or conclusions for submission
- Summarising academic literature in a manner that bypasses learning or uncritically selecting readings for assessed work. Finding literature using appropriate/approved AI tools is acceptable.
- Analysing data or generating interpretations without human-led analysis
- Fabricating, manipulating, or obscuring sources, data, or methods
- Directly inputting the whole or sections of questions, exercise or task descriptions from UCT course assessments, as this violates UCT's IP policies
- Inputting confidential, sensitive, or personally identifiable data into public AI systems
- Such uses are likely to constitute academic misconduct or breaches of research ethics.

1.1.6 Declaration of AI use

Where AI use is explicitly permitted, students must include a clear declaration with their submission. This should state:

“I have used [name of AI tool], as permitted by the lecturer, for the purpose of [brief description of use]. I take full responsibility for the final content of this submission.”

Failure to declare AI use, or use of AI beyond what is permitted, will be treated in line with UCT’s rules on plagiarism and academic misconduct.

1.1.7 AI use in research

For research activities, EGS aligns with UCT Senate Ethics in Research Committee guidance on generative AI. AI tools may support certain stages of the research process, but their use must be:

- Transparent and disclosed where relevant
- Ethically reviewed where human, animal, or sensitive data are involved
- Consistent with authorship, accountability, and data protection requirements

Researchers remain fully accountable for AI-assisted outputs, including errors, bias, or misrepresentation.

1.1.8 Final position

The EGS Department recognises the value of AI literacy as a graduate attribute, but prioritises deep disciplinary understanding, ethical practice, and intellectual independence. AI tools may support learning and research when used carefully and transparently, but they must never replace critical thinking, scholarly responsibility, or human judgement.

Students and staff are encouraged to discuss uncertainties about AI use with lecturers or supervisors before proceeding.

1.2 Consequences of inappropriate AI use

The EGS Department’s position on the consequences of inappropriate use of AI is guided by [the UCT Policy for the Prevention and Management of Academic Misconduct by Students](#). The Department will evaluate the severity of the violation and act accordingly.

According to the UCT policy, students “will only be given credit for work that is their own and work that has been duly and appropriately referenced. . . . [O]nly those portions of the work that are the student’s own work and have been appropriately referenced should be awarded any marks. Portions that are not identifiable as the student’s own work and are not duly referenced should not be awarded any marks. Where it is not possible to determine which portions are the student’s own work with reasonable ease and certainty, or none of the work is the student’s own, it will not be possible to award a mark to the work submitted. The only possibility in such cases is to give it a mark of zero.”

Additionally, the Department may make a decision to refer the student for formal disciplinary action.